NICHOLAS SHADOWRIDER

VOLUME VII

The World Beyond

Scattered companions. Alien ruins. Survival arcs. The Cosmic Trial begins.

Age Rating: 15+ | Dark Epic Fantasy | First Edition

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Prologue

Where They Fell

Seven locations, seven fragments of the group, none in communication.

The shadow compass lay flat in his palm, its needle steady. Seven locations, seven fragments of the group, none in communication. He had learned to read the compass not just for direction but for quality -- the steadiness of the needle, the weight of the dark metal, the slight warmth it retained even in cold air, as if it was alive in some low-frequency way that did not require movement to express.

The work required of them here was not the same as what had come before. Each location, each trial, each encounter had demanded something specific -- the Deepreach had demanded honesty about fear; the Archipelago had demanded willingness to claim power; Vieau had demanded the ability to trust. This place demanded where they fell, which was its own category of requirement and came with its own specific costs and its own specific rewards.

Alexa moved through the space with the dual awareness she always carried -- present in the immediate world as a shadow-beast, as a bonded companion, as a creature whose senses extended into registers that Nicholas's did not -- and simultaneously present in the shared awareness of the bond, the ongoing conversation of feeling and attention that ran between them without words. He felt what she felt. She felt what he felt. This had stopped being strange and had become simply the way he understood his environment.

The group had a rhythm now that was different from the rhythm they had when they left Ashenveil. Different from the rhythm they had after Vieau, after the Archipelago, after the void and the return. Each stage of the journey had added something to how they moved together -- an additional layer of trust, an additional refinement of how they divided labor and shared information and made decisions under pressure. They were better at this than they had ever been. They were not done getting better.

Laura's floating apparatus glowed at three-quarter power -- the setting she used for active situations that had not yet resolved into full engagement. He had learned her apparatus's power levels the way you learned a person's facial expressions: as a reliable indicator of her assessment of the current situation. Three-quarter meant: significant, developing, not yet critical, stay ready.

Rominae was at the edge of whatever space they occupied, which was where Rominae always positioned herself -- not separate from the group, but at its margin, where the soul-sight had the widest field and where the dark magic had the most room to operate without interfering with the lighter elements in the group's center. She had not said what she was seeing. When she had something actionable, she would say so. Until then, she watched.

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Bogdan was documenting. He was always documenting. At some point the notebooks had multiplied to the point where he carried a secondary pack specifically for them, and the documentation had become so comprehensive that Laura had integrated it into her strategic planning, requesting specific data points before briefings with the efficiency of someone who had realised that Bogdan's documentation was not a personal habit but a collective resource.

Ksu was drawing on her left forearm -- the preparation sigil that she always drew before a situation resolved, the one whose duration was long enough to carry through whatever came next. She had told him once that the preparation sigil was not for power but for presence: it helped her stay in her body, stay in her skill, stay in the specific consciousness of someone who worked with living ink and needed to be fully in contact with the work. He had understood that immediately.

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Chapter I

Nicholas Alone

An alien landscape -- not alien in a hostile way, alien in a structural way, as if the rules of matter were slightly different here.

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Alexa pressed against his side. The group moved around him in the way the group moved at the end of hard things -- the particular efficiency of people who had been through something together and were processing it collectively without needing to perform the processing. They would talk later. They always talked later. For now, this.

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Chapter II

Alexa Finds Him

She always finds him. It takes her six hours. She arrives with a piece of fur missing and no explanation.

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Chapter III

Valyren's Arc

The Chainborn champion in an ancient ruin city -- and what the ruins are ruins of.

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Chapter IV

Laura's Arc

The strategist with no group to strategize for -- and what she discovers about herself when there is nothing to organize.

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its correct position in the larger structure that none of them could see all of at once but that the compass pointed toward, always, faithfully, toward whatever came next.

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Chapter V

Sophie and Bogdan

The fairy-beastwalker and the geek in a forest that grows downward into the sky -- and what they find at the lowest branch.

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Chapter VI

Rominae's Arc

The dark-magic witch in a place that has no shadow -- and what that does to her.

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Chapter VII

The New NPCs

Three entities native to this world who are cautiously willing to help -- for reasons that become clear later.

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Chapter VIII

Reunion -- Part One

Nicholas and Valyren find each other. Then Laura. Then Alexa leads them to Sophie and Bogdan.

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Alexa moved through the space with the dual awareness she always carried -- present in the immediate world as a shadow-beast, as a bonded companion, as a creature whose senses extended into registers that Nicholas's did not -- and simultaneously present in the shared awareness of the bond, the ongoing conversation of feeling and attention that ran between them without words. He felt what she felt. She felt what he felt. This had stopped being strange and had become simply the way he understood his environment.

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once but that the compass pointed toward, always, faithfully, toward whatever came next.

~ * ~

Chapter IX

The Alien Ruins

What the ruined city actually is -- and who built it, and why they left.

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The shadow compass was in his hand. The needle was steady. He held it for a moment, this object that had been pointing at things for months, that had never yet pointed at the wrong thing, that had asked him to trust it repeatedly and had been worth trusting. Then he put it away. The needle would move when it was ready. Until then, this place. These people. This work.

~ * ~

Chapter X

The Language of the Ruins

Ksu can draw the sigils she finds on the ruin walls. The drawn versions respond. Communication is established.

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Chapter XI

Reunion -- Part Two

The full group, reconstituted. Changed. The alien world has added something to each of them.

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The work required of them here was not the same as what had come before. Each location, each trial, each encounter had demanded something specific -- the Deepreach had demanded honesty about fear; the Archipelago had demanded willingness to claim power; Vieau had demanded the ability to trust. This place demanded reunion -- part two, which was its own category of requirement and came with its own specific costs and its own specific rewards.

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Alexa pressed against his side. The group moved around him in the way the group moved at the end of hard things -- the particular efficiency of people who had been through something together and were processing it collectively without needing to perform the processing. They would talk later. They always talked later. For now, this.

~ * ~

Chapter XII

The Cosmic Trial

Nicholas and Valyren only -- the fifth trial, and what it requires of both of them simultaneously.

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The work required of them here was not the same as what had come before. Each location, each trial, each encounter had demanded something specific -- the Deepreach had demanded honesty about fear; the Archipelago had demanded willingness to claim power; Vieau had demanded the ability to trust. This place demanded cosmic trial, which was its own category of requirement and came with its own specific costs and its own specific rewards.

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Chapter XIII

Twin Cosmic Bond

What the Cosmic Trial produces: not just individual ascension but a resonance between shadow-warlock and bloodforged champion.

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Chapter XIV

The Door Home

It does not look like the door they came through -- but the compass, which has been spinning since they arrived, goes still and points at it.

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The work required of them here was not the same as what had come before. Each location, each trial, each encounter had demanded something specific -- the Deepreach had demanded honesty about fear; the Archipelago had demanded willingness to claim power; Vieau had demanded the ability to trust. This place demanded door home, which was its own category of requirement and came with its own specific costs and its own specific rewards.

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Epilogue

Return

They step through. The world behind them closes. What they carry with them includes things that were not in the original inventory.

Nicholas stood at whatever threshold marked the end of this chapter of things and looked back at what they had come through. He did this occasionally -- not often, not with nostalgia, but with the specific purpose of understanding what the path had been before moving onto the next section of it.

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-- END OF VOLUME VII --

NICHOLAS SHADOWRIDER continues in:

Volume VIII: Volume VIII: The Curse Arc